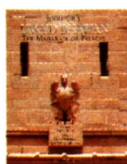




THE PALACE COUP

A book on one of India's royal palaces offers insights into princely ambition



**JODHPUR'S UMAID BHAWAN:
THE MAHARAJA OF PALACES**

by AMAN NATH

Text by Fred R. Holmes and
Ann Newton Holmes

IBH; Price: Rs 2,500; Pages: 172

■ By Dilip Bobb

Back in 2002, Gaj Singh II, erstwhile Maharaja of Jodhpur, celebrated the golden jubilee of his Raj Tilak, his ascension to the throne, by recreating the original ceremony and celebrations at Umaid Bhawan, the palace which his royal ancestors built and is now a luxury heritage hotel run by the Taj Group. Babji, as his friends call him, had more than one reason to recreate his coronation. He was four years old when he was crowned and only had vague memories of the event. For those two days, Umaid Bhawan returned to its former glory as a royal palace, and not as a five-star accommodation for nostalgic or awestruck tourists. It was a truly awesome experience, made more so by the grandeur of the sprawling palace with its 400-plus rooms, banquet halls, Art Deco murals and underground swimming pool, marbled corridors, and its vast immacu-



ROYAL SUITES: Umaid Bhawan (top); the swimming pool

lately maintained grounds.

Even more impressive was the grand scale of the design and architecture, the intricate detailing and workmanship, and the motifs, mottos and royal insignia found all over the palace and the façade. As a showpiece of Indian royalty, there are few better, even if the architectural style has been the subject of much confusion and debate. Umaid Bhawan was conceived and built during the time of Babji's grandfather, Maharaja Umaid Singh. He chose an ageing British architect, Henry Vaughan Lanchester, of the firm

of Lanchester & Lodge, who had competed with Lutyens to design the Viceregal Lodge (later to become the Rashtrapati Bhawan) but had been sidelined by the latter who saw him as a threat to his pre-eminence. Lanchester's designs for Rashtrapati Bhawan are said to have influenced the design for Umaid Bhawan. Ultimately, however, the design for the palace was the shared vision of a hugely talented architect looking for his signature structure in India and a young, ambitious maharaja competing with 36 generations of ancestors.

Finally completed in 1925 for the princely sum of Rs 3.5 crore, it blended eastern aesthetics with Western